

GLOBAL CASE COMPETITION AT

HARVARD

2026 CASE

THALES - RHEINMETALL

The competition is brought to you by the IFSA Network



WELCOME LETTER

Dear Competitor,

Welcome to the 2026 Global Case Competition at Harvard.

By entering this competition, you've chosen to do more than submit a deck. You've chosen to test your judgment, work under pressure, and engage with a case that reflects the realities of modern markets—complex, geopolitical, and rarely clean.

This year marks the 11th edition of the competition. What started as a student initiative has grown into a truly global platform, supported by an international network of participants, judges, and industry professionals. Over the years, the competition has been defined less by trophies and more by the relationships, ideas, and ambition it has fostered across borders.

As you approach the case, lean into your team. Challenge each other. Pressure-test assumptions. The strongest teams are not those who agree the fastest, but those who argue well, think independently, and execute together.

In a world shaped by shifting power dynamics, reindustrialisation, and capital following geopolitics, the ability to think clearly and collaborate effectively matters more than ever. This competition is your opportunity to demonstrate exactly that—before peers, academics, and practitioners who operate at the intersection of strategy and markets.

With participants from six continents and over 150 universities, the competition remains genuinely global. Ten teams will advance to the finals, presenting their work in a hybrid format to ensure equal footing for all.

We look forward to reviewing your submissions, which have consistently shown depth, originality, and rigor. Treat this as both a challenge and a signal—of how you think, how you decide, and how you perform when it counts.

Best of luck in the weeks ahead.

- The Executive Board

RULES & REGULATIONS

1. All work submitted must represent the team's own words, ideas, and work. Using public material is allowed, but you are required to cite the sources. Failure to cite sources will be considered plagiarism, and will be sanctioned accordingly.
2. Only listed participants are authorized to read and use the case.
3. Before submitting your case, write team member names and your school name **only** on the front cover of your Case Packet. This is to ensure that cases are graded without bias.
4. You are required to submit a presentation in PDF format. You **may** provide additional data or models in an Excel document, **if you wish**. There is a **35 content slides limit and 5 appendix slides limit** to each team's presentation deck (inc. title slides).
5. If needed, you may provide extended solutions in a .zip format or through a WeTransfer (or similar) link.
6. We require that all references be made in a Harvard Style Referencing Format.
7. Teams are not allowed to share their solutions publicly before the final round on March 22nd.
8. Use any provided material and additional research at your own discretion.
9. You are not allowed to use generative AI to write your deck.
10. In the event that you have any organizational questions, please send an email to gcch@ifsa-network.com. To keep the competition fair, we **cannot** provide any feedback or help solving the case.
11. Submit your solution before Sunday, February 22nd at 11:59 PM EST to the following form:

[CASE SUBMISSION FORM](#)

Please ensure it's named "TeamName_UniversityName.pdf".

Late submissions will not be accepted. It is not fair to those who submit their work on time.

**We wish you all the best and we look forward
to your submissions!**

2026 CASE

THALES - RHEINMETALL

SHOULD THALES LEAD THE CREATION OF A PAN-EUROPEAN INTEGRATED DEFENSE CHAMPION THROUGH A MERGER WITH RHEINMETALL?

You are successfully completing IFSA's Network Analyst Program. Given your division's strong track record, you are assigned to analyse a transaction that could meaningfully reshape the global balance of power.

Your Managing Director has just returned from the World Economic Forum (WEF) in Davos. Beyond successful business meetings, a dominant theme emerged: geopolitics is once again a primary driver of global markets and industrial strategy.

As Europe faces increasing strategic pressure from both Western allies and Eastern powers, policymakers are reassessing the continent's defense posture. In response, Europe is accelerating efforts to strengthen military sovereignty, expand domestic industrial capacity, and keep pace in an increasingly explicit global arms race.

One of Europe's leading defense groups, **Thales Group**, has driven European defense capabilities for decades. Its systems, expertise, and technological leadership remain central to European armed forces. However, Thales is now assessing whether its current capacities are sufficient, and is considering expanding into industrial-scale ground warfare and weapons systems. The board has approached your Managing Director for strategic advice.

A natural candidate is **Rheinmetall**. With more than a century of operational experience, Rheinmetall is a cornerstone of European land warfare, spanning armored vehicles, artillery, and ammunition. Thales is evaluating whether such a combination could create a true pan-European defense champion.

Thales has granted IFSA Network exclusive rights to assess this potential acquisition, placing your team at the center of one of the most significant M&A opportunities of the decade. The transaction raises substantial strategic, geopolitical, and financial challenges, and Thales expects a clear recommendation.

Your task is to prepare a pitch addressing the following:

- Should Thales merge with Rheinmetall?
- What competitive advantages would the transaction unlock (technology, sovereignty, scale, market positioning)?
- Are there alternative targets better aligned with Thales's objective of building a European defense champion?

The Managing Director expects the deck by February 22nd, 2026. Winning this internal competition secures a \$10,000 bonus and reinforces IFSA's standing in high-profile advisory mandates.

RECOMMENDED GUIDELINE

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Outline your solution, and your most important arguments, in no more than one slide.

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

Introduce the reader to the problem by:

- Providing a brief history of the case
- Analyzing both companies in terms of their history, operations, market position, and strategic direction
- Giving an overview of the relevant industry/sector

CHAPTER 2: FINANCIAL DUE DILIGENCE

What would an acquisition mean in financial terms?

- Do a complete valuation of Thales and Rheinmetall. What's the best method to do this valuation?
- What do your results imply? Is this merger feasible?
- What are the appropriate metrics that show if the deal is profitable or not?
- How should this operation be financed?

CHAPTER 3: NON-FINANCIAL DUE DILIGENCE

Is this deal a good idea from a strategic point of view?

Topics of this chapter may include, but are not limited to:

- Synergies, if the merger is successful?
- Threats that may prevent a successful integration?
- How would Thales benefit from Rheinmetall's capabilities?
- Implications for the relevant industry/sector?
- What potential risks could arise from this merger, and how might they impact the overall implications of the deal?

RECOMMENDED GUIDELINE

CHAPTER 4: CONCLUSION

What should Thales do and why?

- In this final chapter, you should derive your solution by balancing the pro and counter arguments for the deal. If you come to the conclusion that Thales and Rheinmetall should merge, provide a brief outline of a possible deal and the next steps to follow. If you believe that Thales should not go for this merger, provide an alternative investment strategy they could undertake to acquire similar capabilities, and strengthen its position.

This only serves as a recommendation of procedure. You are not constrained by it in any way, and are encouraged to explore further avenues and thought processes.

Please read the Rules & Regulations carefully.



BEST OF LUCK

SUBMIT YOUR CASE SOLUTION TO
[HTTPS://FORMS.GLE/V5STKFENTKVFZWZK7](https://forms.gle/V5STKFENTKVFZWZK7)
BEFORE 11:59PM EASTERN STANDARD TIME
FEBRUARY 22ND, 2026

WE CANNOT ACCEPT LATE SUBMISSIONS

